

RED SKULL

The most dangerous of all Nazi agents



The Red Skull's Cosmic Cube, could alter reality.

Johann Schmidt was born in a German village. His mother died giving birth to him and, after failing to drown the newborn child, Johann's father committed suicide. The orphaned Schmidt became a beggar and thief, though he sometimes took menial jobs. Schmidt was working as a bellboy in a hotel when Adolf Hitler, the dictator of Nazi Germany, paid a visit there.

A PERFECT NAZI

Recognizing in Schmidt's eyes a hatred of all humanity that mirrored his own, Hitler decided to turn him into "the perfect Nazi." Hitler oversaw Schmidt's training, presented him with a skull-like head mask, and named him "The Red Skull." Answerable only to Hitler himself, the Red Skull undertook a wide range of missions for the Third Reich, especially acts of terrorism.

It was in order to have an American counterpart to the Red Skull that the US government gave "super-soldier" Steve Rogers the identity of CAPTAIN AMERICA. Shortly before America entered World War II, the Red Skull first battled his greatest enemy, Captain America. During the war the Red Skull commanded numerous military missions. He rose to become the second most powerful man in the Third Reich, feared even by Hitler.

During the fall of Berlin, Captain America fought the Skull in Hitler's bunker. A bomb caused a cave-in that seemingly killed the Skull. However, an experimental gas kept the villain in suspended animation for decades.

BACK FROM THE DEAD

In the 1950s, communist agent Albert Malik impersonated the Skull, but eventually the original was found and revived. Since then, Captain America has repeatedly thwarted his bids for global domination. At one point, the Skull died, but ARNIM ZOLA transferred the Skull's consciousness into clone of Captain America. By accident, his own "dust of death" caused the Skull's new head to resemble a living red skull.

The Skull made many enemies, including General LUKIN, who sent the WINTER SOLDIER to kill him.

Before dying, the Skull used a Cosmic Cube to transfer his mind into Lukin's body. With the help of



During World War II the Red Skull repeatedly battled Captain America and his partner Bucky.

FACTFILE

REAL NAME

Johann Schmidt

OCCUPATION

Terrorist; conqueror

BASE

Nazi Germany, later various secret bases around the world.

HEIGHT (original body)

6 ft 1 in; (cloned body) 6 ft 2 in

WEIGHT (original body)

195 lbs; (cloned body) 240 lbs

EYES (both bodies) Blue

HAIR (original body) Brown; (cloned body) Formerly blond, later none

FIRST APPEARANCE

Captain America Comics #7 (October 1941)

Totally ruthless, brilliant subversive strategist; excellent hand-to-hand combatant and marksman. Uses lethal "dust of death," which causes a victim's head to resemble a ghastly red skull.

RED SKULL

POWERS



The Red Skull and Captain America are symbolic of tyranny and freedom.

ESSENTIAL STORYLINES

• *Tales of Suspense* #66

The first time that the fascinating origin of the Red Skull was revealed.

• *Tales of Suspense* #79-81

The Red Skull is revived in modern times and steals the Cosmic Cube.

• *Captain America* #101-104

The Red Skull unleashes the Fourth Sleeper robot and leads his Nazi army of Exiles.

his daughter, SIN, CROSSBONES, and DR. FAUSTUS, the Skull set up the assassination of Captain America at the end of the CIVIL WAR (see pp. 84-5). Recently, Lukin was killed, but the Skull transferred his mind away and will no doubt resurface soon.

PS, MF



The Red Skull so hates Captain America that he will even murder people who impersonate the real Captain and Bucky.